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Housing crisis is key in mayoral contest

Bass and Raman both promise to address affordability. But their approaches differ.

By Jack Flemming

As election season draws to a close, Los Angeles is stuck in a housing market where no one seems to be winning.

Developers aren't building new apartments. Many tenants can't afford rent, even though prices have largely been frozen for the last four years and home values are dropping.

L.A. is one of the most expensive cities in the country, so a key question in the race for mayor is which candidate can make living here a bit cheaper.

Both Mayor Karen Bass and challenger Nithya Raman champion the cause of housing affordability. Bass signed a handful of directives during her first term that fast-tracked affordable housing projects and created incentives to build apartments, while Raman has spearheaded strong tenant protections during her time on the City Council.

The two have spent much of the last few years working in political parallel — Raman even endorsed Bass before joining the race herself. Now that they're running against each other, the candidates are laying out similar visions for housing, but with subtle differences that could affect affordability.

Raman has embraced YIMBYism — the "yes in my backyard" movement — while Bass has been hesitant to label herself either YIMBY or Not In My Backyard. L.A. has long suffered from an identity crisis, caught between the single-family homes of its past and the multifamily developments that density advocates say are needed for its future. The question of what and where to build is key to affordability and what the city will look like.

In a debate this week, Bass highlighted her accomplishments in paving the way for new affordable housing, while Raman asserted that housing production is still lagging and Bass isn't doing enough.

Both candidates brought up housing in their opening statements and continued to reference the issue over the course of the hourlong debate.

[See **Affordability,** A6]



Eric Thayer Los Angeles Times

TALLY, an autonomous, AI-powered inventory robot, scans shelves at a Ralphs grocery in Los Angeles.

AI employee of the month

At some grocery stores in L.A., robots are monitoring for inventory amid growing union concerns of the machines replacing humans

By Ella Chakarian

The robot takeover looks a lot different from what we see in Hollywood thrillers.

Even as artificial intelligence-powered humanoid robots dance, box and beat human running-speed records, the physical bots showing up in our daily lives in Los Angeles are less Terminator and more R2-D2.

On a Wednesday afternoon at a Ralphs on Pico Boulevard, a skinny, 6-foot-tall tower of sensors rolled through the aisles. It made low beeping noises, its lights flickering purple and green. A small screen on the top of the tower had two blinking eyes and a small line of text. "Hi, I'm Tally!"

"Robot! Robot!" a young boy yelled. Some adults looked confused; others laughed.

Ricardo Valadez, a 62-year-old real estate agent from Mid-City and a Ralphs regular, said he felt like the robot was stalking him around the store but was reassured by an employee that it just checks the shelves to see what is missing or out of place.

"I was kind of like, 'What the hell is that?' " Valadez said. "I don't know why; I felt that it was following me."

With a recent rollout in some L.A. grocery stores, the inventory bot, built by Burlingame, Calif.-based Simbe Robotics, joins the other free-range forms of physical AI that are already a part of everyday life in Los Angeles, such as food delivery bots and Waymos.

From inventory management to marketing and checkout, retailers are increasingly adopting automation. The retail automation market could jump to $77 billion by 2034 from $28 billion in 2025, according to estimates from market research company Fortune Business Insights.

Simbe says more than 3,000 of its bots have been contracted to monitor shelves worldwide. Kroger, the parent company of Ralphs, is using hundreds of them after pilot projects that started in Indianapolis and Cincinnati, and recently spread to California.

"Simbe provides shelf intelligence technology that helps store teams more easily identify and address products that are low or out of stock,

[See **Robots,** A12]

DOJ SUES TO BLOCK COUNT OF 20,000 BALLOTS

California leaders blast 'meritless' last-minute claims that the named voters are noncitizens.

By Kevin Rector

The Trump administration on Thursday sued California over its handling of voter fraud claims, asking a federal court to immediately bar the state from counting ballots from about 20,000 voters statewide — many in Los Angeles County — who the administration alleges are "likely noncitizens."

The lawsuit is highly unusual, particularly given that California voters have already begun voting in the Nov. 3 midterms via mail ballots, experts said.

It's also "meritless," highly inappropriate and based on questionable federal data that have proved wildly inaccurate in other states, state officials said.

"This is a sad, desperate attempt by Trump to use his politicized Justice Department to try to suppress California voters just three weeks before Election Day," Gov. Gavin Newsom wrote on X. "Courts have made clear the federal government has no role in running state elections. We will defend free and fair elections in the Golden State and call out every authoritarian attempt to undermine our democracy."

"Every count, recount, hand count, lawsuit, and audit has found that there's no widespread voter fraud in the U.S.," California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta wrote on X. "The Trump Admin's last-minute demands are meritless, and we look forward to making our case in court."

U.S. Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche, in his own statement, defended the lawsuit.

"State-facilitated voter fraud is unacceptable in the United States of America," he said. "If found responsible in a court of law, the State of California will have seriously undermined confidence in our electoral system and violated laws that protect our nation's representative system of government."

The lawsuit states that "as part of an investigation into unlawful voting," U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services conducted a "multiagency and multilevel review" of state voter and federal citizenship data and determined with "high confidence" that about 20,000

[See **Ballots,** A6]

Widespread ICE surge in Central Valley

Arrests tear apart families. Fear keeps many students and farmworkers at home.

By Brittny Mejia and Ruben Vives

Across California's Central Valley, a reported surge in Immigration and Customs Enforcement operations that began last week has disrupted agricultural communities, sparked confrontations and left families scrambling to locate detained relatives.

In the city of Kerman, Mayor Maria Pacheco confronted ICE agents on Thursday as they detained people.

"You're not welcome in my city," she told an agent in a video posted on Facebook. "You've taken enough people yesterday. We don't want you here."



Larry Valenzuela CalMatters

DETENTION officers escort a handcuffed person into a federal immigration office in Fresno last week.

The following day, a 72-year-old Fresno resident shot and wounded an ICE agent who police said had fallen asleep on the resident's daughter's front lawn, appeared "intoxicated and agitated" and allegedly assaulted the resident. Prosecutors have charged the agent with assault, elder abuse and other crimes.

In Madera, organizers postponed the third annual Oaxacan Guelaguetza festival amid growing fears, according to the group's Facebook account.

Fresno City Councilmember Miguel Arias said the enforcement operations led to a drop in school attendance and sparked student protests Friday.

"We're seeing across-the-

[See **ICE,** A8]

Ukraine is 'done' with truce

Kyiv strikes refinery after accusing Russia of not heeding ceasefire. Zelensky sees betrayal by Trump.

By Susie Blann



Diego Herrera Carcedo Anadolu

UKRAINIANS take cover during an airstrike in Sloviansk on Thursday after a guided-bomb attack.

KYIV, Ukraine — Ukraine attacked a Russian oil refinery Thursday, abandoning a brief truce involving energy-related targets that it said Moscow did not heed, as Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky said he felt betrayed by President Trump.

The drone strike started a fire at the refinery about 180 miles southeast of Moscow in Russia's Ryazan region, according to the Russian Defense Ministry and Ryazan Gov. Pavel Malkov. Russia's Astra online news outlet posted what it said was a photograph of the blaze.

The strike could further complicate Kyiv's relations with Trump, which have soured again in recent days amid deepening tensions with Washington.

Zelensky said he was outraged by Russia's continuing aerial bombardment of his country's energy infrastructure in apparent defiance of Trump's demand on Sunday for both sides to halt

[See **Ukraine,** A4]

Execution won't be livestreamed
President Trump says families of victims may attend death by firing squad of Ft. Hood shooter. **NATION, A5**

Span will close for 16 months
Locals are concerned about construction on the Vincent Thomas Bridge to replace its deck. **BUSINESS, A10**

More Dodgers coverage online
For full coverage of Game 4 against Milwaukee, go to *latimes.com/dodgers*.

Weather
Sunny and very hot. L.A. Basin: 97/72. **B6**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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Voters wary of outside influence

Many in L.A. County are confident of local elections officials, however, poll finds.

By Itzel Luna

Los Angeles County voters are concerned about a host of voter fraud issues that could disrupt the Nov. 3 general election, even though they have a high degree of confidence in local elections officials, according to a new poll funded by the nonprofit California Community Foundation.

Nearly three-quarters of respondents expressed concern that false rumors and misleading information online could confuse voters or make them believe that their vote won't count, the poll found. Other top concerns included politicians interfering with the election and mail-in ballots getting lost, stolen or delayed.

Still, most of the voters surveyed expressed confidence in the county's handling of election proceedings, with 68% saying L.A. County does an excellent or good job at running elections and counting ballots.

Once presented with information about how the county handles elections, that number rose to 72%. Around three-quarters of respondents also believe that the upcoming election will be fair, secure and accurate, the poll found.

The online poll was conducted from Sept. 30 to Oct. 6 by Tulchin Research, a San Francisco-based public opinion firm. It surveyed 500 voters in L.A. County considered likely to cast ballots in the Nov. 3 election and has a margin of error of 4.4%.

"Voters feel good about the local officials running

[See **Poll,** A7]